



Change in rule: BCCI revived a 2021 rule, letting CSK retain M.S. Dhoni as an “uncapped” player for Rs. 4 crore, since he hasn’t played internationally since 2019. PTI

former players as scouts, then their word perhaps doesn’t matter as much and, in any case, the scouts don’t sit at the auction table, do they?

Most of the guys who suddenly become crorepatis are overwhelmed, firstly by their sudden good fortune and then by the nervousness of getting to rub shoulders with those they have admired and perhaps never even dreamt of meeting. They are often not even part of their State’s squad of top 30 players. So now, to get into a group where there are great players in the game from different countries with different styles, approaches, and even different accents is never easy. In all these years, it is hard to recall an uncapped player bought for huge numbers who has justified his inclusion in the team. Maybe over the next couple of years, he may get a bit better with experience, but if he is playing in the same local league, then that chance of improvement doesn’t get much better.

What does happen is that if in the next auction his price comes down, then the pressure of expectations also comes down and the player plays a lot better. **This season has shown that players bought for crores in the first cycle and now at a much reduced fee are showing better results.** It could well be the experience of just being with some of the greats of the game, but more often than not, it is the reduced expectations with the lower fee that has eased the burden and allowed them to try and replicate what they do in their local city league.

A whole lot of the players bought for huge amounts simply fade away

as their hunger and drive are satiated. To the franchises, it perhaps doesn’t matter as they may feel it’s good riddance, but Indian cricket takes a bit of a beating at the loss of any player whether he has been successful or not.

To accommodate Mahendra Singh Dhoni, who became an uncapped player before the auction last year, the limit was raised to Rs 4 crore.

Maybe it is time to relook at that and reduce it further so that Indian cricket does not lose out on talent that seems to flounder its way with the pressure when auctioned for crores.

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